

SPI 387: Education Policy

Week 3 Precept

Week 3 Readings

- San Antonio Independent School District v. Rodriguez, 411 U.S. 1 (1973)
- White, R. S., Stitzlein, S. M., Knight Abowitz, K., Gottlieb, D., Schneider, J., & Kogan, V. (2022). Are school boards failing? Educational Leadership, 79(1), 42–47.
- Jackson, C. K. (2018). Does school spending matter? The new literature on an old question (NBER Working Paper No. 25368). National Bureau of Economic Research.

San Antonio Independent School District v. Rodriguez, 411 U.S. 1 (1973)

San Antonio Independent School District v. Rodriguez, 411 U.S. 1 (1973)

- Case the challenged Texas school financial system because of its use of property taxes (resulting in funding disparities).
- There is no fundamental right to education

Kogan v. White et al. Debate

Kogan's Critique

- Pluralism takes away from the main purpose of a school system: improve student outcomes. By prioritizing the concerns of adults, we are taking away from education quality
- Proposes the following reforms:
 - Holding school-board elections on cycle
 - Reworking accountability systems to focus on each school's contribution to learning
 - Timing release of school ratings with school-board election campaigns

White et al.'s Rebuttal

- Challenges Kogan's argument that we ought to have a state decision-maker
- Argues that the democratic nature of school boards is a good thing, and it allows communities to pursue goals of their education system other than student achievement outcomes.
- Just because there are flaws in school board governance doesn't mean we need to eliminate it but instead pursue reforms

Jackson, C. K. (2018). Does school spending matter? The new literature on an old question

Jackson, C. K. (2018). Does school spending matter? The new literature on an old question

- On average (though not for all contexts), money matters
- Finds a positive association between increasing school spending and improved student outcomes



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EdWorkingPaper No. 25-1251

Unequal Foundations: Racial Disparities in School Building Conditions in New York State

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School infrastructure is a critical yet often overlooked factor shaping student health, learning, and well-being. This study examines racial disparities in public school building conditions across New York State using data from building inspections linked to demographic and fiscal data. Schools serving more students of color are significantly more likely to have poor overall conditions, inadequate ventilation, mold, and reduced access to athletic fields, gymnasiums, and health offices. A Kitagawa-Oaxaca-Blinder decomposition shows that local property taxes are the largest contributor to racial gaps in building quality, while progressive state building aid helps reduce these disparities. These findings highlight persistent infrastructure inequities and the need for targeted investments to ensure all students have access to safe and supportive learning environments.

Ambali, O., Baker, D., & Wolf, J. (2023). Unequal foundations: Racial disparities in school building conditions in New York State. *Albert Shanker Institute & The New School Center for New York City Affairs*.

Ambali et al.

- Seeks to examine the racial disparities in public school building conditions across NY State using building inspections linked to demographic and fiscal data
- Found that there was a racial gap in the school conditions- schools that served predominantly non-white students were less likely to have adequate building conditions than schools that served predominantly white students
 - Since this only looked at the “adequacy” of the conditions, we also may be overlooking that the schools with adequate conditions may also be *exceeding* the quality- thus creating even larger disparities
- Property taxes were the primary contributor to widening the gap while state building aid decreased the gap

Discuss as a group: Do school building conditions matter for a child's education/educational success?

Should the New York state government and/or respective school boards intervene in districts that have found to have worse school building conditions?

Why might a centralized authority (as opposed to a school board system) be beneficial and why might it be harmful? What groups would favor it and who may be against it?

Exit Ticket

- What outstanding reflections do you have regarding the governance and financing of schools?
- Also, please leave any comments and/or critiques about our first two precepts! :)

Identify pertinent values

Educational Goods

Knowledge, skills, dispositions, and attitudes that constitute the capacity for:

- Economic productivity
- Personal autonomy
- Democratic competence
- Healthy personal relationships
- Regarding others as equals
- Personal fulfillment

Distributive Values

- Adequacy
- Equality
- Benefitting the less advantaged

Independent Values

- Childhood goods
- Parents' interests
- Respect for democratic processes
- Freedom of residence and of occupation
- Other goods

Identify key decisions

Use evidence to evaluate options in light of pertinent values

Weigh values and evidence to make Decision

